

# Open Source as Institutional Infrastructure

Lessons from the UC OSPO Network

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# The invisible layer

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Research data workflows run on open source:

- Data collection, cleaning, analysis, visualization
- Reproducibility tooling: containers, workflows, version control
- Repositories and scholarly infrastructure

**92%** of researchers use software; **67%** say their research would be impossible without it.

The people keeping it running are increasingly called **Research Software Engineers (RSEs)** - a growing professional community with no standard institutional home.

Hettrick et al. (SSI, 2014/2022)



# We've been here before

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People in this room helped build the open data movement:

- FAIR principles: from aspiration to institutional expectation
- Data management plans embedded in grant workflows
- Curation, provenance, and stewardship as professional services
- Open science infrastructure: repositories, PIDs, metadata standards
- **FAIR4RS**: FAIR principles now extended to research software

**Software is the next frontier** — and UC has been showing the way for 50 years: BSD Unix, Apache Spark, RISC-V, Ray. The pipeline from university research to global infrastructure is not rare or accidental.

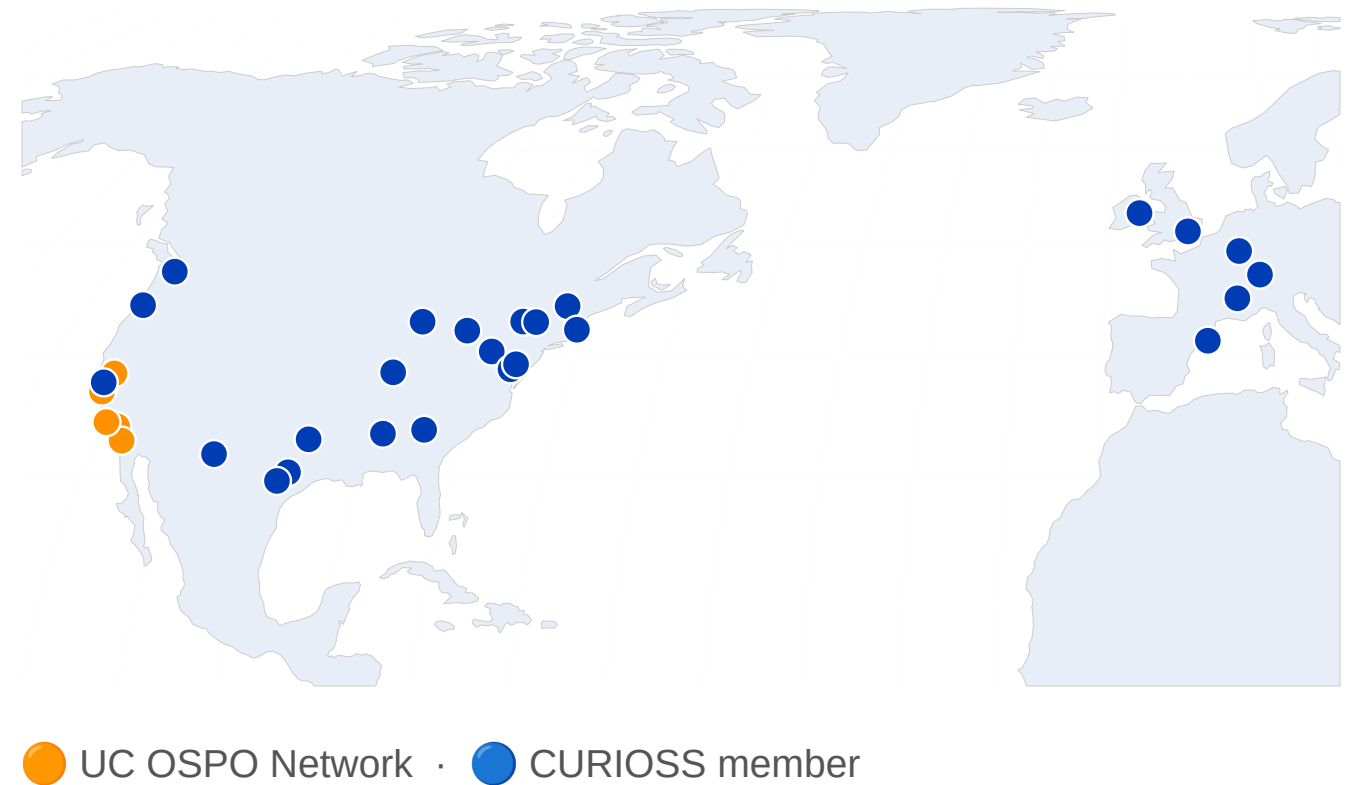
“The research done in academia was the seed. Foundations provided the soil. But the community was the sun.”



# What is an academic OSPO?

An **Open Source Program Office** supports, governs, and promotes open source within an institution.

- Originated in industry: ~77% of large tech companies have one
- First academic OSPO: Johns Hopkins, 2019
- **34 academic OSPOs** in CURIOS member worldwide and growing
- Core functions: policy, licensing guidance, best practices, education, community



# The UC OSPO Network

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A **multi-campus collaboration** treating open source as shared infrastructure.

- 6 campuses: Santa Cruz, Berkeley, Davis, Los Angeles, Santa Barbara, San Diego
- Launched April 2024, funded by the Alfred P. Sloan Foundation
- **\$1.85M** in external funding to date
- Lead: UC Santa Cruz, the first OSPO in a large state university system
- Serves 280,000+ students and 25,000+ faculty

Acts as a **neutral convener**: no single campus, company, or grant cycle can pull the work away.

Ruff (2026) UC Open Summit · [youtu.be/eBriL3CDNeo](https://youtu.be/eBriL3CDNeo)



# Three thematic areas

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## Discovery

Mapping who does what across the UC system — repos, contributors, tools, and practices



## Sustainability

Keeping projects and communities healthy through licensing, project health, and community support



## Education

Coordinated training and learning pathways across campuses



# Discovery: knowing what's there

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The 4 Ps framework, applied at system scale:

- **People:** who contributes to OS software at UC?
- **Product:** what has been built?
- **Practice:** how do faculty and staff engage?
- **Perception:** what are contributors' experiences?

Tools: GitHub pipeline (200,000+ repos scanned; ~52,000 institutionally affiliated across 10 campuses), network-wide survey (294 respondents), UC Open Repository Browser (UC ORB)

Gomez et al. (2025) [arxiv:2506.18359](https://arxiv.org/abs/2506.18359) · Scarlett et al. (2025) [doi:10.31235/osf.io/p8bx6\\_v1](https://doi.org/10.31235/osf.io/p8bx6_v1)



# Sustainability: keeping it running

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**58% of UC open source contributors are also maintainers.** Not users: stewards.

What they asked for most: sustainability grants, computing infrastructure, learning communities.

**#1 challenge: finding time to write documentation.**

Nationally: **60%** of maintainers are unpaid; **43%** report burnout.

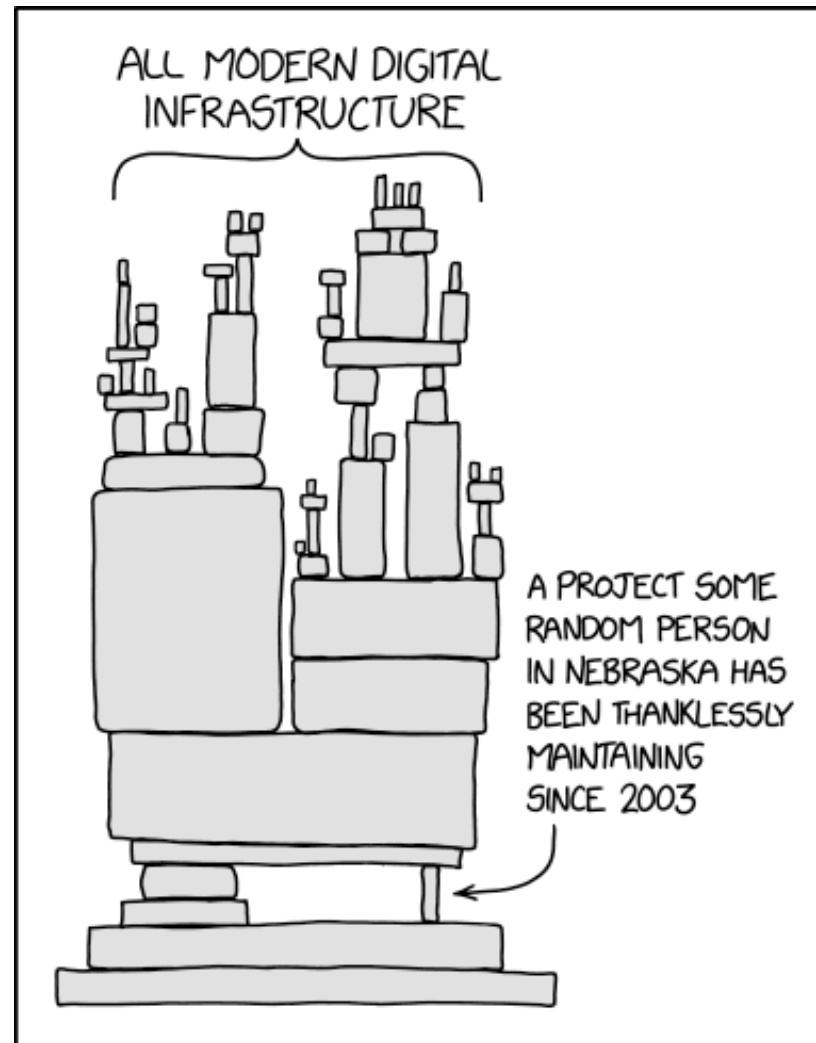
Network services:

- Cross-campus licensing working group (UCOP + tech transfer + IT)
- Project health assessment (OSSPREY)
- Containerization support · Community management





# The dependency problem



XKCD #2347 'Dependency': a towering stack of blocks labeled 'All modern digital infrastructure' balances on a single tiny block labeled 'A project some random person in Nebraska has been thanklessly maintaining since 2003'. By Randall Munroe.

xkcd #2347 (CC BY-NC 2.5) · UC survey: 58% of contributors are maintainers · Tidelift (2024): 60% unpaid, 43% burnt out



# AI and open source: a new pressure

AI code generation is changing what it means to maintain a project.

- **Slop PRs:** AI-generated contributions that look complete but are off-spec, shallow, or carry subtle bugs
- Review burden grows while maintainer capacity stays flat
- The OSS projects that trained the models are now flooded by their output
- Security risk: AI-generated code in dependencies with undetected vulnerabilities

**OSPOs are developing responses:** contribution disclosure policies, AI-aware code review norms, project-level guidance.

Baltes, Cheong & Treude (2026) arxiv:2603.27249 · GitClear (2024) “Coding on Copilot”

## The structural shift

70% of new AI PhDs go straight to industry

(a decade ago: 50/50)

90% of notable AI models come from a handful of companies

Academia is being sidelined from the systems it helped create.

Ruff (2026) UC Open Summit ·  
[youtu.be/eBriL3CDNeo](https://youtu.be/eBriL3CDNeo)



# Education: training as infrastructure

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Gap analysis → curriculum inventory → learning pathways

- Inventoried existing materials: Carpentries, CodeRefinery, The Turing Way, UC-specific content
- Organized by topic (licensing, sustainability, community) and by role (contributor, maintainer, manager)
- Published at [ucospo.net/education](https://ucospo.net/education)
- Coordinated with data literacy programs and Carpentries infrastructure



# Governance: intra vs. inter campus

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Not everything should be shared. Some things only work at scale.

| Intra-campus                     | Inter-campus                      |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Initial pilots                   | Platform and tool development     |
| Local relationship-building      | Licensing and best practices      |
| Faster, context-specific support | System-wide discovery             |
| Unique institutional context     | Field-specific community building |

Network governance: OSPO Leadership Group + working groups; GitHub-based project management.



# Lessons from two years

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What the network model enables that single campuses cannot:

1. **Shared staffing:** community manager, licensing specialist, technical roles
2. **Policy leverage:** the network has standing with UCOP; individual campuses do not
3. **Data at scale:** the GitHub and survey analyses require system-wide scope to mean anything
4. **Equity:** smaller campuses get services they could not build alone
5. **A replicable model:** \$1.85M produced something other state systems can follow



# Where this meets your work

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For data professionals, the OSPO sits at the intersection of:

- Research software engineering ↔ data management
- Licensing compliance ↔ open data policy
- Reproducibility tooling ↔ FAIR / FAIR4RS
- Training infrastructure ↔ data literacy programs
- RSE community ↔ library research support

## For your institution:

- Where does open source software governance currently live?
- What would it take to treat it as infrastructure rather than a side project?



# What you can do right now

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If you advise on data-intensive research, you are probably already helping with code.

**The network has already built the resources:**

- [README.md](#) — template + guide (Laura Langdon, UC OSPO)
- [LICENSE](#) — guide includes UC-approved options
- [CONTRIBUTING.md](#) — template + guide
- [CODE\\_OF\\_CONDUCT.md](#) — Contributor Covenant + guidance
- [CITATION.cff](#) + Zenodo release → citable, versioned DOI

**Going further:**

- [Growing a Community Around a Project](#) — UC OSPO
- [Sharing Research Software: Reproducible, Citable, and Discoverable](#) — Carpentries Incubator lesson (covers [pixi](#), CITATION.cff, Zenodo, discoverability)



## Learn more / connect

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**UC OSPO Network:** [ucospo.net](https://ucospo.net)

- Education site: [ucospo.net/education](https://ucospo.net/education)
- Mailing list, Slack, events calendar

**Global network:** [curiOSS.org](https://curiOSS.org) — 34 academic OSPOs worldwide and growing

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